

THE PROMISE AND PRICE OF AMBITION

FIFA's push for a bigger World Cup may be fuelled by global reach and rising revenue, but threatens the tournament's **competitiveness.**

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The more the merrier' — FIFA president Gianni Infantino and U.S. President Donald Trump would be high-fiving over this phrase, as the 2026 World Cup begins with a staggering 48-team roster, expanding from 32 teams in the 2022 Qatar edition.

The dress rehearsal for such a move has already been done: the FIFA Club World Cup last year, which expanded from seven to 32 teams, generated revenue of \$2.16 billion, compared to \$76 million from its previous two editions.

For this year's World Cup, which already appears aggressive in its revenue generation (FIFA listed tickets worth over \$2 million for the final), the larger roster seems planned along similar lines.



Off-balance: An expanded field could lead to more one-sided contests between strong and weak teams, disappointing fans who value tighter, more competitive matches. PICS: GETTY IMAGES